

NOMAD — A SHORT FILM

A near-future thriller about the last man who can tell a person from a copy — and the business that no longer needs him to.

A man goes looking for the friend who got out. He finds the version of him that stayed behind.

The Business

Before it is a mystery, NOMAD is a transaction. A relocation service moves burnt-out northern workers to paradise for one fee — *your dollar, three times the life*. What it actually trades is the spread between two currencies: harvested likenesses billed out in dollars as tireless remote workers, and their originals warehoused where housing is priced in pesos. The paradise is a render. The friend on the video call is a product. And the operation's best recruiting tool is the person it took most recently — warm, specific, and always about to see you next week.

The Story

NOMAD opens on three men who should have gone home. A dead sales department after hours, a mini-putt course built out of an emptied floor, and a handshake getting invented — flubbed three times, then perfected, with a dumb open-handed beat on the end that none of them can explain. Across the floor, a colleague's monitor is still attending meetings; the colleague hasn't been seen since March. It is the only warm room in the film, and everything after is measured against it. Somewhere in the dark, a phone propped against a stapler is filming — footage that was never for anyone, which will matter more than anything else shot that year.

WILL works identity verification. He audits the machine's fraud calls from a floor that emptied years ago — motion-sensor lights clicking on ahead of him like a runway for nobody, a coffee machine brewing a full pot at 8:55 so he can pour its only cup. He is the top human performer on a system that scores him 96.8 against its own 99.1, and he is very good at the one thing he is being eroded out of: knowing when a face isn't a person.

A year earlier his friend CAIRNS left — loudly, for the service, because he did the math on his life and the math said leave. Since then Cairns calls from a pool, tanned and expansive and always about to disappear. The floor's last holdout is JOHN, who has never left the country, and who wants nothing more complicated than his friends in the same room.

When the floor closes, Will sells his face to the same service and flies south. He moves into an apartment somebody was still moving out of — eleven years of a child's height marks pencilled down the door frame. He haggles for limes and overtips for coffee, delighted both times, and doesn't hear the correction when his one word of Spanish is handed politely back to him. On a morning street he passes a gaunt man holding a phone up to strangers like ID — IDENTITY NOT VERIFIED, REFERENCE ON FILE — and sees him for one full second before the reflex he has spent a year putting down puts this down too.

Then a video call, and the old handshake — muscle memory — and the thing on the other end knows it, and lands one move wrong. What follows is the film's centerpiece: Will turns his profession on his best friend,

scrubbing tonight's call against the shaky 2am phone video from the office, laying laugh over laugh until they land like a flam — one drum hit, split in two, 0.4 apart, every time. No human is that consistent. The metadata resolves to one building, twenty minutes away.

Upstairs: no pool. Capture rigs, humming racks, scanned locations resold as somewhere else, an outbound queue of warm emails all signed by a woman who is a mail-merge — and, on the wall, the dashboard with the two columns. On one screen, his own welcome ad, refining. From the next row, his own laugh. The real one.

The film ends where it has to. The system Will served reads the polished model as authentic and the live man as SYNTHETIC — retained for reference, a specimen the model keeps until it doesn't. And in a half-dismantled office on the other side of the world, John takes a call from a tanned, easy, glowing "Will" who knows about the bracket and the putter and can't make it, buddy — and almost catches it. Almost. Then, alone in the half-dark, John runs the handshake to nobody. Both hands open at the end. Like putting something down.

Form. ~16 minutes. 24 scenes. v3.3, locked. Mostly behaviour; dialogue only where it earns the space.

Why now. Verification is quietly becoming the infrastructure of personhood — your face is your bank, your border, your job. And the remote-work diaspora has made identity portable exactly when it became harvestable. NOMAD puts the two together and answers in the smallest possible terms: two friends, a stupid handshake, and the one thing a dataset can never contain because nobody ever recorded it. Except once, by accident, half of it carpet.

Achievable. A dying office floor, an apartment, a storefront, one server room. Small cast. No stunts. The paradise is a render — which is the point, and the budget.

Blue Sheep · info@bluesheepfilms.com